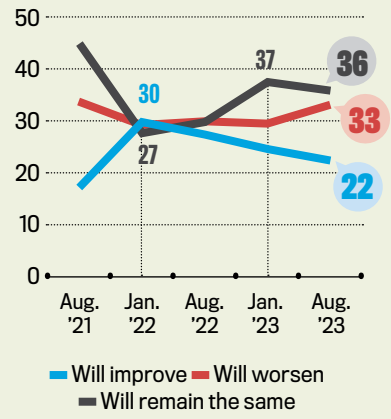
with the survey in January this year, when 53.9 per cent rated the Modi government's handling of the economy as outstanding or good. It was also way below the response in January 2021 where, in the midst of the Covid pandemic, as many as 66 per cent had hailed the government. The relief measures extended by the government to the poorer sections as well as the micro, small and medium scale enterprises (MSMEs) were well acknowledged then, but now their impact has worn off. The government will, therefore, need to show more action on the ground to generate a feelgood factor, be it by creating new jobs or reining in runaway prices.

FALLING ECONOMIC STATUS

This could also be the reason why only 44 per cent of the respondents said that Prime Minister Narendra Modi handled the economy better than Dr Manmohan Singh, the PM in the two previous consecutive stints of UPA regime, compared to 50.9 per cent who said so in January 2023. So, in a matter of six months, the perception regarding the handling of the economy has gone through a sea change. As has the response to the question on how the respondents' economic status has changed since Modi took charge as prime minister. As many as 38 per cent of the respondents in the latest survey feel that their economic status has deteriorated, compared to 35 per cent in the January 2023 and August 2022 editions. This is the second highest percentage of respondents saying their economic status has deteriorated since January 2016 (42 per cent had said they were in a crisis in August 2016). Those who felt the economy had improved comprised just 29.5 per cent in the latest survey, dropping from 33.3 per cent in the previous survey in January.

Q. Is your household income/ salary likely to improve?

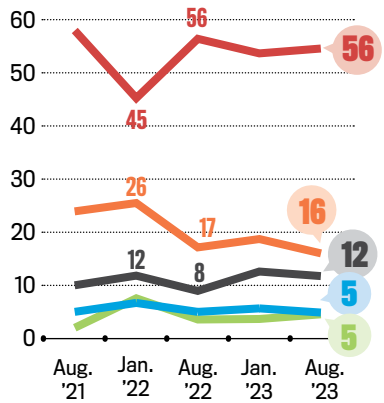


One in three people fret that money woes will get worse



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Q. How do you view the unemployment situation in the country?



All figures in percentage

Despair over the lack of job opportunities persists

It is but natural then that the pessimism that things may not get any better, at least in the next six months, will only grow. Indeed, as many as 33.8 per cent of the respondents felt that the Indian economy was going to get worse over the next six months, an increase from 31.4 per cent who said so in the January 2023 MOTN survey. As many as 30.5 per cent felt that the economy will improve in the next six months, but this again was a drop from 31.1 per cent who felt so in January. As many as 33.3 per cent of those surveyed felt their household income/ salary will come down, which is the highest in the past four MOTN surveys. This leaves no doubt that unemployment is an extremely serious concern. Though consumer-facing sectors such as retail and travel and tourism have seen recovery post Covid, it is still largely a factor of pent-up